

University of Debrecen CoARA Action Plan 2024-2027

General Overview:

Mission Statement of the University of Debrecen

As an institution of excellence of the higher education in Hungary, in the spirit of the Magna Charta of the European universities, the University of Debrecen contributes to the development of the universal science and the Hungarian society by the highest level, multifaceted and multidisciplinary training, research and development. This mission is performed jointly by the lecturers, employees and students, by committed to quality and by cooperating with Hungarian and international partners. As a result of this:

- the University of Debrecen can be characterised as an internationally renowned institution of education, scientific research and development in the field of medical and health sciences, agricultural sciences, humanities, health sciences, legal sciences, economic sciences, technical sciences, pedagogy, social sciences, natural sciences and music;
- by aiming efficiency, flexibility, the increase of responsiveness, dynamic development and the rationalisation of management, it becomes a more and more determining intellectual centre of Eastern Hungary, with a close connection of the surrounding regions of the neighbouring countries;
- by considering the international processes and the compliance with social demands, it intends to release higher and higher-qualified professionals by the extension of the higher-level vocational training, the elaboration and performance of the programmes of the multi-cycle training (bachelor, master, PhD), by the diversity of postgraduate trainings, continuous further education and the utilisation of distant education, with a view to the lifelong learning;
- as a research university and the central institution of the regional corporate innovation network, it is one of the key actors of economic development as well, therefore, it facilitates the cooperation of the private sector, the business life, the local government and the central government in the field of regional and transboundary education, research and development programmes.

The University of Debrecen is able to prominently serve Hungary and the Hungarian citizens primarily based on its mission statement, by preserving its diversity, unity and systematic activity in every education level, from the pre-school education until the adult training. In addition to serving the education, research, curative and preventive activity and agriculture, the institution is committed to reinforce its relationships with the social and economic sector and as the third mission of higher education, to perform its cultural and sports tasks.



Research Assessment and its Reform:

	Commitment	Scope	Action	Timeframe
1	Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.	Changes in assessment practices should enable recognition of the broad diversity of: - valuable contributions that researchers make to science and for the benefit of society, including diverse outputs beyond journal publications and irrespective of the language in which they are communicated; - practices that contribute to robustness, openness, transparency, and the inclusiveness of research and the research process including: peer review, teamwork and collaboration; - activities including teaching, leadership, supervision, training and mentoring. It is also important that assessment facilitates the recognition and valorisation of diverse roles and careers in research, including: data steward, software engineer and data scientist roles, technical roles, public outreach, science diplomacy, science advice and science communicator roles to name a few.	1.1 Assessment of the current research evaluation system through performance evaluation of the various faculties of the University of Debrecen. 1.2 Comparison of the current research evaluation system with the expectations set by CoARA 1.3 Development of discipline-specific and research career recommendations based on the collected information.	January 2024 August 2024



2	Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	Research assessment should rely primarily on qualitative assessment for which peer review is central, supported by responsibly used quantitative indicators where appropriate. Peer review is the most robust method known for assessing quality and has the advantage that it is in the hands of the research community. It is important that peer review processes are designed to meet the fundamental principles of rigor and transparency: expert assessment, transparency, impartiality, appropriateness, confidentiality, integrity and ethical considerations, gender, equality and diversity. To address the biases and imperfections to which any method is prone, the research community re-assesses and improves peer review practices regularly. Revised, or potentially new, criteria, tools and processes appropriate for assessing quality could be explored alongside peer review. Moving towards assessment practices that rely more heavily on qualitative methods may require additional efforts from researchers. Researchers should be recognised for these efforts and their contributions to reviewing peers' work should be valued as part of their career progression.	Further development of the institutional Current Research Information Systems (CRIS) in order to present the peer review activities of researchers.	2025-27
---	--	--	---	---------



3	Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publicationbased metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	Inappropriate uses of journal- and publication-based metrics in research assessment should be abandoned. In particular, this means moving away from using metrics like the Journal Impact Factor (JIF), Article Influence Score (AIS) and h-index as proxies for quality and impact. 'Inappropriate uses' include: • relying exclusively on author-based metrics (e.g. counting papers, patents, citations, grants, etc.) to assess quality and/or impact; • assessing outputs based on metrics relating to publication venue, format or language; • relying on any other metrics that do not properly capture quality and/or impact.		
4	Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	Recognising that the international rankings most often referred to by research organisations are currently not 'fair and responsible', the criteria these rankings use should not trickle down to the evaluation of individual researchers, research teams and research units. Research organisations should also be mindful that public communication (e.g. the active advertising of an institution's rank) can contribute to the perception that research quality conflates with ranking positions. Where ranking approaches are deemed unavoidable, as may be the case in forms of evaluation beyond the scope of this Agreement such as benchmarking and performance reviews of countries or institutions, the methodological limitations of such approaches should be acknowledged, and institutions should avoid trickle-down effects on research and researcher assessment.	• To examine the institutional implementation of the More Than Our Rank initiative • Raise awareness on the limitations of rankings and ensure that all materials that refer to league tables or rankings clearly acknowledge their limitations	December 2024 April 2024 and ongoing



5	Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	Resource allocation by assessment authorities and research funding and performing organisations is a necessary condition for reforming assessment practices. Resources should be allocated as is needed for each organisation to achieve the changes that will enable adherence to the Principles and to implement the Commitments. This includes resources to: • implement changes in research assessment, including planning and progress monitoring; • raise awareness among all actors; • educate, train and support researchers and any other staff involved in assessment, including peer-reviewers and assessors; and • support the necessary infrastructure such as tools and services for the transparent collection and processing of data on research assessment practices.	• Engage with CoARA working groups and national chapter to support systemic reform, exchange good practice and monitor global progress, • Raise awareness of research assessment reform at the institutional level in the different career status (PhD students, Library and Publishing Committee), • The use of plain language summaries in order to popularize the highlighted articles,	January 2024 and ongoing
6	Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes			January-August 2024
	6.1 CRITERIA FOR UNITS AND INSTITUTIONS With the direct involvement of research organisations and researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and	Criteria for the assessment of research performing units and organisations, including universities, research centres, and research infrastructures, should be reviewed and adapted, and new criteria developed where needed, based on evidence. This should be done in close collaboration with assessors and those that will be assessed, including research organisations and researchers. The changes should increase the ability to assess quality	• Review current research assessment criteria and their implementation, ensuring that these are robust and comply with responsible research assessment principles.	



	research performing organisations, while promoting interoperability	by enabling recognition of all contributions to quality research by research units and institutions. Such recognition includes that of early sharing of data and results, open collaboration, teamwork; and consideration of contributions to the research ecosystem, knowledge generation and scientific, technological, economic, cultural and societal impact. National / regional / organisational authorities and evaluation agencies should coordinate to ensure their methodologies and processes are interoperable, while simultaneously respecting the necessary adaptation to each context.		
	6.2 CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS With the direct involvement of researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and researchers that are adapted to their context of application	Criteria, tools and processes should be reviewed and developed together with researchers in different disciplines and at different career stages; and should enable recognition of the diversity of research activities and practices that contribute to research quality, including diverse outputs in different languages. This should increase the ability to assess quality by enabling recognition of all contributions to quality research from research projects and by researchers and research teams. This includes recognition of early sharing of data and results, open collaboration, and teamwork. Reformed practices for assessing individual researchers should consider future potential alongside track record and take into account researchers' individual contexts and careers. They should also recognise that researchers cannot excel in all types of tasks and provide for a framework that allows researchers to contribute to the definition of their research goals and aspirations. Research assessment by	Develop CRIS capacity/reporting functionality that allows consistent and accurate monitoring of a range of qualitative and quantitative information, where staff can easily view, amend or challenge information relating to them.	2025-27



		research funders should consider disciplinary, multi-, inter-, and trans-disciplinary research as well as contributions to knowledge generation and scientific, technological, economic, cultural and societal impact.		
7	Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	Without widespread awareness of the reform and training of those assessed and, crucially, assessors, progress will be slow - if not impossible. Organisations should be clear and transparent about assessment processes and the tools and criteria they use. They should make guidance on their assessment approaches openly available and train those involved in the assessment process. They should allow those assessed to have access to the criteria, data and reviews or deliberation outcomes used in their assessment within the limits of confidentiality. Particular attention should be paid to raising awareness among researchers at all career stages.	• Raise awareness of research assessment reform at the institutional level in the different career stages (PhD students, Library and Publishing Committee), • Provide training sessions and workshops for assessment panels, committees, and faculty members to ensure they understand and adhere to assessment practices	January 2024 and ongoing April 2024 and ongoing
8	Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	While respecting each other's autonomy, organisations should share practices and experiences to facilitate mutual learning. This exchange should include contributing to the development of guidance and common approaches in order to minimise contradictions or incompatibilities between the assessment practices used by different organisations. It should also include sharing of lessons learned to ensure continuous mutual improvements.	• HUNOR experiences exchange • Hungarian National Chapter	January 2024 and ongoing



9	Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments	Demonstrating progress made towards implementing the Commitments and adherence to the Principles is an important part of this initiative. Organisations should commit to regularly update each other and their communities on their adherence and progress. This process involves being open to scrutiny from their own communities, sharing successes as well as challenges, and communicating their experiences to facilitate collective progress	Hungarian National Chapter	
10	Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	Growing evidence shows that current assessment processes that rely on publication and journal-based metrics are prone to multiple biases. As approaches using more qualitative research assessment are piloted by several organisations (e.g. narrative and evidence-based CVs, new assessment frameworks and indicators), it is important to evaluate and monitor their impact based on evidence and rigorous methods. Organisations should contribute to the evidence base on research assessment in order to make this possible. For example, it could be achieved by making data that can be used for research on research available, by participating in research on research, or by funding research on research. Data sharing should be the minimum commitment and data should be shared through open infrastructure, while respecting personal data protection.	To examine the institutional implementation to SCOPE Framework for Research Evaluation	2025-2027